

FrenchTech Weekly

Issue #237 — November 2, 2024 | Your weekly dose of French startup news

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Exotec Raises EUR 335M to Scale Warehouse Robotics

ROBOTICS • LOGISTICS • SERIES D • LILLE, FRANCE

Exotec, the Lille-based warehouse robotics company, has secured a massive EUR 335 million in its latest funding round, valuing the company at over EUR 2 billion. The company, which now employs roughly 1,000 people, designs and manufactures the Skypod robotic system for warehouse automation. Clients include major retailers and logistics providers across Europe and North America.

"We are building the next generation of warehouse infrastructure," said CEO Romain Moulin. "Our technology reduces picking time by 5x while improving accuracy to 99.99%."

KEY FACTS:

Founded: 2015 | Employees: ~1,000 | HQ: Croix (Lille metro)
Total raised: EUR 335M+ | Valuation: >EUR 2B | Sector: Warehouse Automation / Robotics
Key clients: Uniqlo, Carrefour, Decathlon, Gap | Skypod system deployed in 20+ countries

Doctolib Expands Beyond Booking — But Is It Tech?

HEALTHTECH • SAAS • PARIS

Doctolib, the Paris-based health appointment platform with 2,800 employees, continues to expand its suite of tools for healthcare practitioners. While technically a tech company, its focus remains firmly on the healthcare/medical vertical — building scheduling, teleconsultation, and practice management software for doctors and clinics. The company is not a typical engineering/IT consulting target, as its tech stack is deeply specialized for the healthcare domain.

Editor's note: Doctolib is included for completeness but is not a traditional IT services buyer. Their engineering is largely in-house.

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Mistral AI: The Hottest (and Most Debated) French Startup

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE • LLM • PARIS • MEGA-ROUND

Mistral AI, the Paris-based AI research company founded by former Meta and DeepMind researchers, has raised a massive funding round bringing its total to over EUR 1 billion. With approximately 600 employees, the company is focused exclusively on developing large language models and AI infrastructure. While the funding numbers are eye-catching, Mistral's needs are very specific: AI researchers, ML infrastructure engineers, and GPU compute. The company is unlikely to be a significant buyer of traditional IT consulting or engineering services, though they may need specialized cloud/infrastructure support.

Tags: #AI #LLM #FrenchTech #DeepTech #VentureCapital #Paris #OpenSource #Mistral #funding #unicorn #GenerativeAI #foundation-models

Ynsect Pivots Again — Insect Protein Startup Struggles

BIOTECH • AGRITECH • AMIENS • SERIES C

Ynsect, the Amiens-based insect protein startup with roughly 400 employees, continues to face challenges scaling its mealworm farming operations. The company has raised significant venture capital but has yet to achieve profitability. While innovative, the company is too small and too far outside the IT/engineering consulting sector to be a relevant prospect. Their technology is in bioprocessing and agricultural automation, not enterprise IT.

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